Bursting

By Andy Griffiths

NOTE: *The humor of this piece comes from the characterizations and the pantomimes. Go really, really big! Think of how many ways you can physically show that ANDY has to go to the bathroom really badly.*

ANDY: **(Pg 1-16)** I'm in the supermarket trying to remember what groceries Mom wanted me to pick up, but I can't think. I can't breathe. I can't do anything. I'm bursting. And I don't mean bursting. I mean BURSTING! I've got to find a toilet. Fast. Then I can come back and think about the shopping with a clear head. Or not so much a clear head as an empty bladder.

INTRODUCTION

Diapers ruined us. They made us lazy from a very young age. The moment we make our flying exit from the womb our butts are wrapped in cloth. Babies and toddlers don't realize how good they have it! They can pee anywhere, anytime, without interrupting their various activities. And babies are busy! But it's not so easy for us. In fact, it's (insert time) on a (insert day). You could be (insert some activity), but instead . . . you are judging a speech tournament. Thank you, by the way. And, thanks to the judge's lounge, you've probably downed at least two cups of coffee and a giant-sized Diet Coke by now. You have to be . . .

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ANDY: I haven't got a second to lose. I run down the aisle and skid around the corner. WHAM! Straight into an old guy with a walker. He staggers forward and crashes into a stack of cans. They go rolling all over the floor.

OLD GUY: Well, don't just stand there -- Help me up!

ANDY: *(Pantomime helping the Old Guy up and helping him with his walker)* The store manager appears. I can tell he's the store manager because his pants are too tight. Plus he's wearing a badge that says STORE MANAGER.

SM: What happened?

OLD GUY: This silly young boy knocked me over. When I was young we respected our elders.

ANDY: It was an accident!

SM: Were you running? There's no excuse. I think you owe this gentleman an apology. Then you

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can pick up all the cans.

ANDY: But I'm bursting! *(to audience)* I get the feeling that I'm going to get out of here quicker if I just do what he says. *(to the Old Man)* I'm sorry, I shouldn't have been running, and I hope you're not hurt. *(to audience, pantomiming picking up cans)* I start picking up the cans. I can't believe how far they've rolled. By the time I've finished, I'm seriously bursting. But I know better than to run out of the store. This time, I just walk very quickly. I get outside the supermarket and into the main shopping mall. I'm looking for a sign pointing to the toilet. There is a man selling pencils outside the supermarket.

MAN: Excuse me, want to buy a pencil? They're cheap – twenty cents each.

ANDY: No, thank you. I haven't got time!

MAN: Just one. One lousy pencil!

ANDY: How many times do I have to say it? I don't want – or need – a pencil. What I need is a toilet. I'm bursting! *(to audience)* His shoulders drop. He sighs heavily. He looks like he's going to cry. If he's trying to make me feel bad, he's succeeding. *(to man)* Okay, *(fumbling for change).* I'll buy a pencil. *(to audience)* All I can find is a dollar. *(to man)* Have you got change? No? Keep the change then.

MAN: No, that wouldn't be right. I'm not looking for charity.

ANDY: Fine, give me five pencils! *(to audience)* He counts the pencils out really slowly, one by one. *(shifting from foot to foot impatiently).* Finally, he hands me the pencils. I run off before figures out another way to waste my time. I'm running as fast as I can, but this shopping mall is too big. There are too many levels. *(running then tripping and stumbling -- looking down at shoes)* My shoelaces have come undone. I hate my shoelaces. Now I have to stop and waste valuable toilet-searching seconds retying them. *(kneeling down painfully to tie the shoes)* It's putting pressure on a part of my body that's already under too much strain. I don't have much time. *(noticing a sign overhead)* Suddenly, I find the sign I've been looking for. A picture of a man, a woman, a wheelchair, and an arrow pointing to the left. *(running toward the toilets)* I can see the toilets up ahead of me. Oh, no. I don't believe it. Closed for cleaning! Should I try to find another toilet or just wait? I'll wait. But I'm bursting. I can't wait. But I can't not wait. I have to go. Right now . . . Hang on! The handicapped toilet is not closed. Can you go to jail for using a handicapped person's toilet when you're not really handicapped?

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(hobbling to the door and slowly pushing it open) It's vacant. I want to go in but something is stopping me. It would be so easy to just slip in here, and yet, so wrong. If I get away with using this toilet, who's to say where or when it will stop? I can't do it. I let go of the door. I might be bursting, but I'm not a criminal.

OLD GUY: Hey! You can't use that toilet! You're not handicapped! Tearing around the supermarket and knocking people over. Using the handicapped people's toilets and stopping the truly handicapped from using them. You're a menace to society. I'm going to call a security guard! Help! Guards! Arrest this boy!

ANDY: He's crazy. I've got to get out of here. He's creating such a racket, you'd think he was being murdered or something. *(running back through the shopping mall)* I pass a shop with an enormous poster of a river in the front window. I can't hold out much longer. I can hear splashing. It's coming from the indoor fountain. Maybe I could go in the fountain. I could get in, stand in the middle, and pretend to be a statue. I could squirt water out of my mouth at the same time. Nobody would even realize . . . But hang on! In front of the fountain is a map of the shopping mall. Fantastic! *(hobbling over to the map)* Hmmmm. And the sound of all that splashing is not making it any easier to concentrate. It doesn't help that the front of the map is suddenly smeared with water. *(turning around quickly)* Two little kids are squirting each other with water pistols. *(to kids)* Quit it! *(reacting to the kids spraying the front of his pants; then to audience)* Right in the front of my pants! There's a guy wearing a rainbow-colored shirt standing next to me. He looks like a hippie but I'll ask him anyway. *(to hippie)* Excuse me, can you help me find the toilet?"

HIPPIE: *(with his eyes half-closed and in a slow voice)* Looks like it's a bit late. *(pointing at the front of Andy's pants)*

ANDY: That's not what you think it is. But it will be if you don't help me find the toilet.

HIPPIE: Chill out, man. *(studying map)* Says there the toilets are at M sixteen on level two. Ummmmm, level three . . . No, hang on . . . level one . . . oops – make that level four.

ANDY: Level four? There's no such level!

HIPPIE: Hey, man, open your mind. There are many levels. More levels than you ever dreamed of. Relax. Take it easy.

ANDY: I can't! I'm bursting! I've got to get to a toilet! Quick!

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HIPPIE: No, man, you're missing the point. The destination's not important. The journey is where it's at.

ANDY: Not when you're bursting it's not! I can't stand still any longer. *(running again)* I see an escalator going up. *(jumping on)* I don't believe it. It's almost too good to be true. At the top of the escalator is a sign. A man, a woman, and a wheelchair. I bound up the last few steps and leap off the escalator. *(bounding and leaping, but then his leg is jerked backward)* My shoelace is caught in the top of the escalator! *(trying to pull foot away and trying to unlace the shoe which traps his finger)* The laces are being pulled tighter and tighter. My finger is turning bright red. It's throbbing. Great! Now I'm bursting ***and*** I've got my shoelace stuck in an escalator ***and*** my finger stuck in my shoe. *(using other hand to pry his heel from the shoe and getting it stuck too - He should be in an awkward "twister" position by now, bent over double, looking upside down through his legs)* Oh, no. I don't believe it. There's nothing I can do, apart from chew my foot off. That's it! Chewing! Only I don't have to chew through my ankle . . . just my shoelace. *(trying to chew through his shoelace and getting his hair caught)* This is like the most impossible and painful game of Twister ever. *(seeing the Old Guy)* Oh, no . . . The old man is coming up the escalator. He's coming right for me. *(being hit by the Old guy and falling over, snapping his shoelace and ripping a chuck of his hair out)* I'm free!

OLD GUY: *(shouting)* Now we're even!

ANDY: *(to Old Guy)* No, we're not. *(scrambling to his feet)* You just did me a big favor! I start running. Only a few feet more. Something is stabbing me in the leg. What is that? I put my hand into my pocket. Aaaggh! Something jabs me in the thumb. It's those stupid pencils. *(pulling pencils out of his pocket and dropping them on the ground in front of him as he is running, he should slip and fall on the pencils, whacking his head on the ground)(long beat as he lies unconscious, then coming to)* Next thing I know I'm being shaken awake. *(opening his eyes)* A fireman is kneeling beside me. The corridor is filled with smoke and I can hear sirens.

FIREMAN: Wake up! Are you okay? You have to get out of here. Fire!

ANDY: He lifts me up again and starts steering me toward the exit. Away from the toilet! I try to head back toward the toilet but he grabs me.*(being grabbed by the arm) (to fireman)* But I have to use the toilet. I'm bursting!

FIREMAN: You'll have to wait. It's not safe! You have to get out of the building.

ANDY: Not safe?! If I don't get to the toilet soon, nobody will be safe. This shopping mall will be

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flooded! *(to audience)* But he's not listening. He's escorting me to the exit. Outside, there are four fire trucks in a row. The firemen are spraying enormous arcs of water onto the building. I overhear the fire chief talking on his walkie-talkie:

CHIEF: All we know is that the fire appears to have started in one of the escalators. Some foreign material may have got in there and shorted the system. Until we can put out the fire, we can't be sure. But to do that, we're going to need backup units . . . as many as you've got. *(wiping sweat from his brow)*

ANDY: Suddenly, I know what I have to do. I can solve my problem and be a hero at the same time. *(to Chief)* Excuse me, you're not going to need those backup units. You've got me! Watch this! *(urinating on the burning building – your back should be to the audience)* Ahhhhhhhhhhhhh! *(to audience, over your shoulder)* Relief! Beautiful relief! The fire is powerless against me. It disappears in clouds of steam. People are gathered around and applauding. The supermarket manager is there. And the pencil seller. And the hippie. Even the old man. Cheering. *(crowd cheering)* I roll over and snuggle down deeper into my blankets. My blankets? What are my blankets doing here? And why am I wearing pajamas? *(blinking, rubbing his eyes as he slowly comes awake)* There's no shopping mall. There are no fire trucks. No people. I'm in my bedroom. In my bed. Wrapped in my blankets. Putting out a fire. Only there's no fire, either *(realizing that he has seriously wet the bed)* . . . I hate that.

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